

PUBLISHED FOR THE LORDS COMMISSIONERS
OF THE ADMIRALTY

AN ACCOUNT OF THE
PRACTICE OF NAVIGATION

UPON THE SOUTHERN OCEAN

PART I · SEAMANSHIP

COMPILED, BY COMMAND, FROM THE JOURNALS OF HIS MAJESTY'S SHIPS,
AND APPROVED THE 24TH OF DECEMBER 1848,

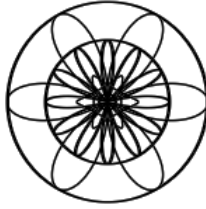
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THE OPEN SEA

This little book is dedicated to all who have watched a coastline sink beneath the stern and felt the first long swell of the open sea.



CHAPTER I

THE DEPARTURE

THE WIND ROSE OVER Plymouth Sound that morning, and the Amaranth swung to her anchor as though impatient to be gone. We had provisioned for a twelvemonth, and the hold was heavy with salt beef, biscuit, and casks of sweet water drawn from the Tavy.

At the turn of the tide we made sail. The town fell away, grey and small, and the Eddystone light stood up alone against the paling sky. The master set a course south by west, and the great business of the voyage was begun.

For three days we ran before a *soldier's wind*, and the people found their sea-legs and their spirits. On the fourth the glass began to fall.

THE FALLING GLASS

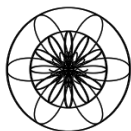
I noted the change in my journal that evening, in the cramped hand of a man **braced against the roll**:

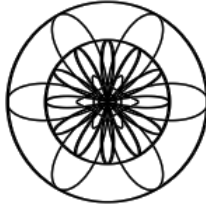
Wind backing to the south-east, and a long swell from the same quarter. The mercury has dropped a full half-inch since the forenoon watch. I like it not.

By the first dog-watch the sky to windward had gone the colour of a bruise.

* * *

We shortened sail while there was yet light to see the work, and I confess I have never been gladder of a well-drilled crew.





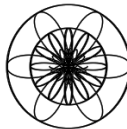
CHAPTER II

THE STORM

BY NIGHTFALL THE SEA ran mountains high, and the Amaranth laboured in the troughs like a spent horse. We struck the topgallant masts and lay to under a close-reefed maintopsail, and still the water came aboard in green walls that swept the waist from rail to rail.

The mainmast sprung in the middle watch. I have never heard a sound so like a cannon, nor felt a deck so lifeless under my feet as in the moment the spar gave way. We cut the wreckage clear and rigged a jury-mast at dawn, our hands raw and our hearts low.

When the gale blew itself out we were four hundred miles from any reckoning, and glad only to be alive.



THE OPEN SEA

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